

The Prom Queen

Sonam Kapoor, 23



RAVI S SAHNI

“I had a unibrow and was really fat,” says Sonam Kapoor, her exquisite face shining with enthusiasm, her long hair being curled by an attentive hairdresser. It’s difficult to believe. But then so is everything else about this Bollywood princess who grew up dancing to Sridevi’s *Hawa hawai* at birthday parties in one of the sprawling homes of Mumbai’s gilt-edged JVPD Scheme, home to the Bachchans, Deols and Chopras. She dances and has been learning it with her Kathak teacher Uma Dogra since she was seven. She reads, more than just the thickest glossy. And when she prepares for a role, she does more than merely obsess about her clothes and close-ups. All of 23, Sonam’s purity of thought impressed Sanjay Leela Bhansali who launched her in *Saawariya* (after he made her sweat as an assistant director in *Black*) as much as it enchants Rakeysh Omprakash Mehra who directed her in the forthcoming *Delhi 6* where she plays an average middle-class girl who wants to become the next Indian Idol. “She’s remarkably unspoilt. A homebody. The kind who will go into the kitchen to fetch water and worry about how hot your *phulka* is when she invites you to eat with her,” he says. Anil Kapoor’s daughter has borne the failure of her first film with uncommon grace but then not for nothing is she everyone’s favourite to be the “next Waheeda Rahman”. As for herself, she just prefers to call herself a “horse with blinkers”.

The Independent Spirit, Abhay Deol, 32

Muscles run in the Deol family. So does charisma. What Abhay Deol lacks in the first, he makes up for in the second. The actor who went to the Otis College of Art and Design for a year and Pasadena City College for two, before trying to make a living from cartooning and making T-shirts in Goa, is currently in New York taking classes at The Art Students League. But the career he has taken a temporary break from after years of walking in and out of sets could well be the envy of an older actor. Commercial success has been as elusive as critical appreciation has been effusive, but that hasn’t stopped Abhay from living every role. And what roles. He’s been an underwhelmingly appreciated writer caught in a mystery not of his making in *Manorama: Six Feet Under*. He’s been Lucky Singh, a Bunty-type slick thief in the wickedly funny *Oye Lucky! Lucky Oye!*. And in *Dev D*, he plays a modern version of the ultimate BMW-MMS spoilt brat, Devdas. The son of Dharamendra’s younger brother, how did Abhay grow up to be the poster boy of independent cinema? “I am an idealist, not a perfectionist,” he says. “If I could just manage a few films which were diverse enough, I felt sure that people would notice, regardless of the box-office fate,” he says. Life is what he learns from constantly. “To make it real it’s important to look into your own life and draw parallels to the character,” he says, adding he is more wary of fame than he is of risky films. “I think it’s the result of seeing fame up close right from childhood. And the desire to explore different characters.” Indeed. As the first choice for offbeat characters with a quirk, he should know all about wanting variety. But as his movies grow from small niche to big noise, he better get used to getting more attention.

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ATUL KASBEKAR